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Andalusia

For other places with the same name, see [Andalusia \(disambiguation\)](#).

Andalusia (Spanish: *Andalucía*) is the southern part of [Spain](#). It has a heritage back to the [Roman Empire](#), and a diverse scenery of deserts, beaches along the [Costa del Sol](#) and [Costa de la Luz](#) and the [Sierra Nevada](#) range, with Iberia's tallest mountains, and Europe's southernmost ski resorts.

Andalusia encompasses an area of 87,268 km² with 8.4 million inhabitants. To the south in the Province of [Cadiz](#) at the very tip of Spain lies the British overseas territory of [Gibraltar](#) where it is separate from [North Africa](#) by just a few miles.

Provinces

Andalusia is divided into eight provinces, each having the same name as its respective provincial capital city.



Andalusia regions - Color-coded map

Almería

Almería offers great beach resorts, national parks, desert and mountains, and the city

of Almería.

Cádiz

Tourists come for its wide sandy beaches behind protective dunes, nature parks, and its quiet mountain landscape with beautiful hiking trails and spectacular views.

Córdoba

Córdoba is rich in history from its time as a Moorish caliphate.

Granada

Granada attracts hordes of visitors for the Alhambra palace, beautiful beaches, and Europe's most southerly ski resort.

Huelva

A land of rugged beaches, pine forests, marshes, lagoons and dunes.

Jaén

This province has the highest concentration of castles in the world outside the Levant. Also one of the world's premier olive oil producers.

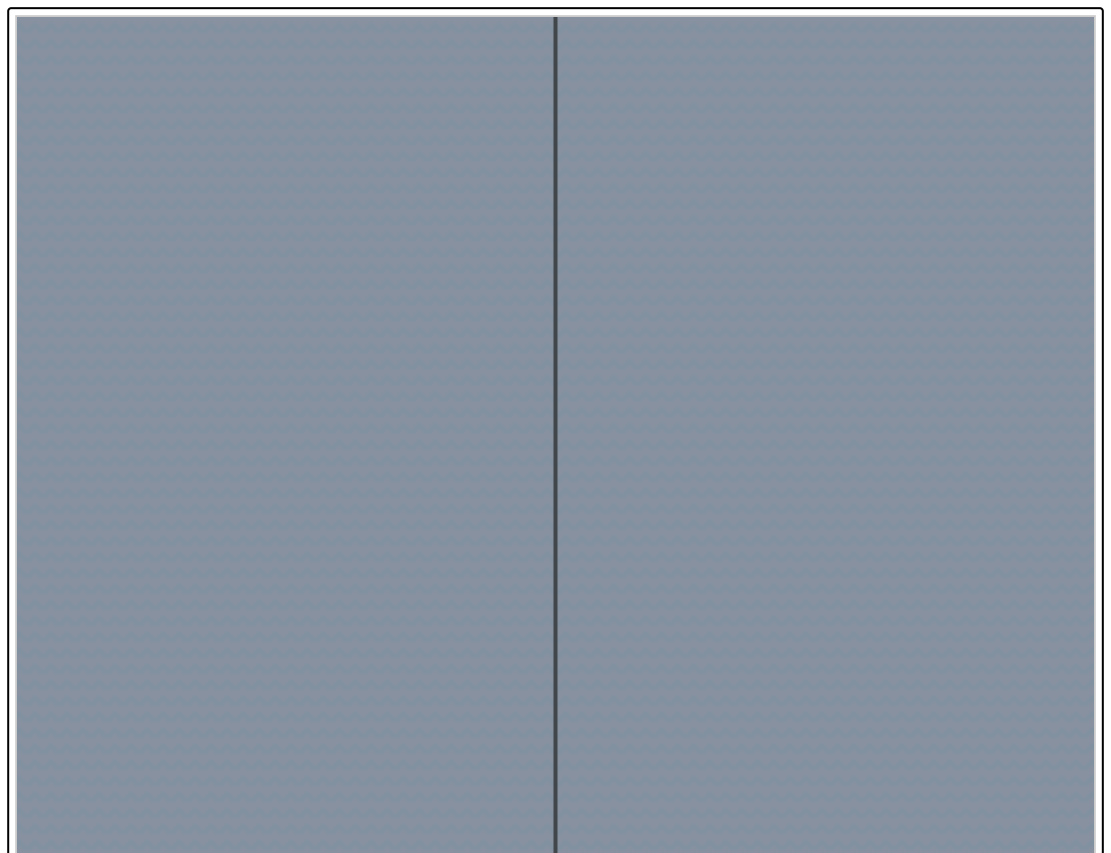
Málaga

A beach and party playground for sunseekers that offers natural and historical sites as well.

Seville

The architecture and culture of its capital made it a stop along the 19th-century Romantic "Grand Tour" of Europe.

Cities



Map of Andalusia

- **1 Seville** — the heart of flamenco, the capital and largest city of Andalusia
- **2 Almería** — lots of medieval remains and fortresses
- **3 Cádiz** — the oldest continuously-inhabited city in the Iberian Peninsula and possibly of all of southwestern Europe
- **4 Córdoba** — used to be the capital of an Islamic caliphate in the Middle Ages
- **5 Granada** — home to the magnificent La Alhambra Palace
- **6 Huelva** — a maritime port town with the oldest football club of Spain
- **7 Jaén** — the world's capital of olive oil and a booming cultural tourism destination
- **8 Málaga** — a large harbour city right on the Costa del Sol
- **9 Marbella** — wealthy resort town on the Costa del Sol

Other destinations

- **1 Ronda** — a beautiful town with an impressive bridge along the deep gorge
- **2 Úbeda** — a Renaissance monumental town of many hills included in UNESCO's World Heritage List
- **3 Cabo de Gata-Níjar Natural Park** — Andalusia's largest coastal protected area, a wild and isolated landscape with some of Europe's oldest geological features
- **4 Alhama de Granada** — an old spa village above a gorge
- **5 Baza Natural Park** — 53,649 hectares of Natural Park
- **6 Costa del Sol** — sunny beaches and beautiful villages along Spain's southern coast
- **7 Júzcar** — a small village painted Smurf blue for 2011 movie *Smurfs II*.
- **8 La Alpujarra** — a mountainous district south of the Sierra Nevada
- **9 Sierra Nevada** — the highest mountains in the Iberian Peninsula, excelling for skiing and hiking

Understand

Andalusia has a rich Moorish heritage, including many fantastic examples of Moorish architecture which were built during the eight centuries when Andalusia, as Al-Andalus, was the centre of the Arab population in the Iberian peninsula. The Moorish rule effectively ended in 1492AD when the Christians recaptured Granada.

Nowadays, the region is a very popular tourist destination with a lot of British and German package holidaymakers coming to stay in the concrete resorts on the Costa del Sol. But if you stay away from the concrete resorts you will find lots of culture, amazing scenery and great food.

Climate

Andalusía has a Mediterranean climate with hot, arid summers and mild, relatively wet winters. Temperatures often surpass 35°C in the summer and average 10.5°C in January and February, the coolest months. Spring warms up gradually, and days in which it is possible to comfortably sunbathe can show up as early as May. Autumn experiences warm temperatures in September, that can possibly extend into October. The region is overall quite sunny, amongst the sunniest in Europe after regions of Italy, Greece and Portugal.

Tourist information

- Andalusia Tourism (<http://www.andalucia.org/en/>) website

Talk

Like most of the rest of Spain, Andalusia's main language is Spanish. Popular tourist areas like Malaga, Marbella, and Cordoba usually have tour guides and shop owners who speak basic English, but do not expect fluent conversations.

Get in

Major airports: Seville (Sevilla), Malaga, Almeria, Jerez de la Frontera.

By car

The main road routes into Andalusia are

The E-1 A-49 from the Algarve (Portugal) to Seville

The E-803 A-66 from Portugal and western Spain to Seville

The E-5 A-4 from Madrid to Cordoba and then Seville

The E-15 A-7 from Valencia and Murcia to Almeria and along the coast

By plane

Malaga has the third biggest international airport in Spain, which a lot of discount airlines fly to. From Malaga, the A-7 E-15 motorway runs westwards along the coast to Gibraltar and eastwards to Almeria and beyond. To head north from Malaga, the A-45 motorway runs to Cordoba. There are also airports in Sevilla, Jerez de la Frontera, Granada and Almeria

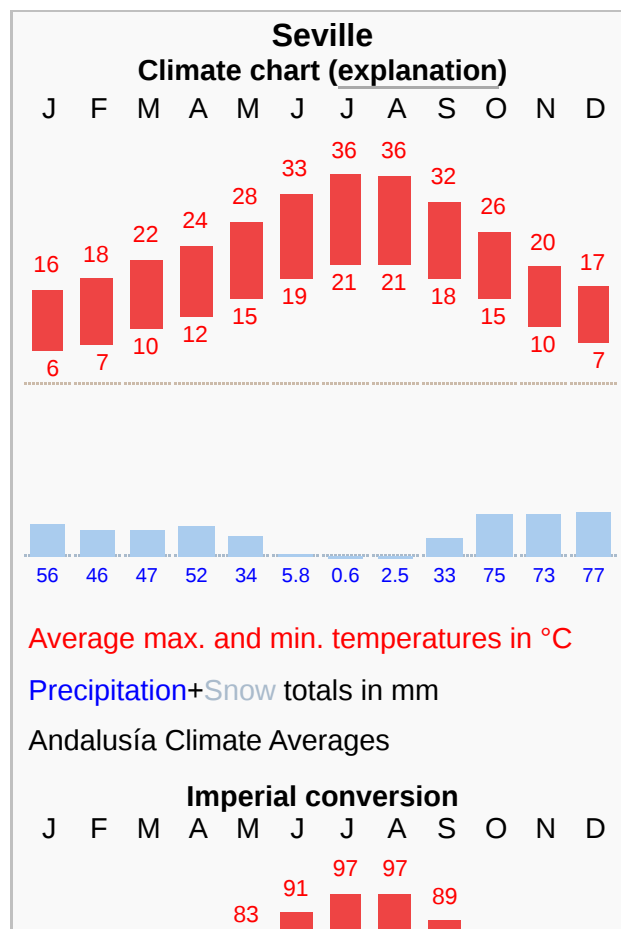
By train

Spain's railway network is not as developed as those of many other European countries, but Algeciras, Almeria, Cadiz, Granada, Huelva, Jaén, Malaga, Cordoba and Sevilla are all served by regular train services. Spain's highspeed AVE network connects Malaga, Cordoba and Sevilla to Madrid. Some of the



Patio de Los Leones in the Alhambra. 

Andalusia is a region steeped in Moorish architecture and the Alhambra in Granada is widely regarded as the pinnacle of Moorish architecture.



other smaller towns are served by less frequent services, see individual city guides for further details. For more info, see the RENFE website (<http://www.renfe.com/>).

Get around

Bus services around Andalusia are provided by

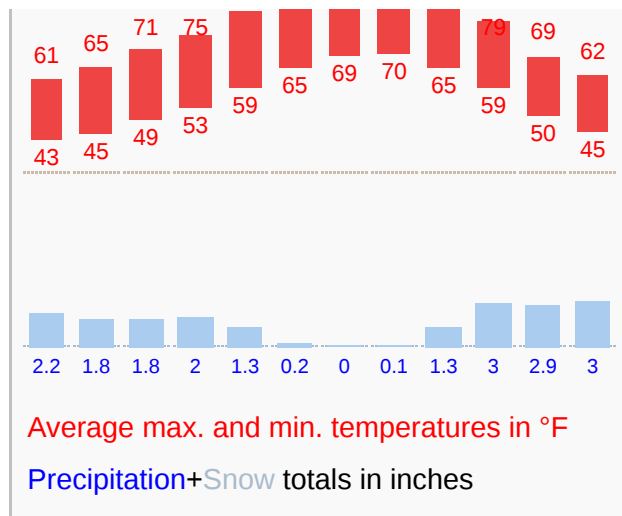
- **Alsa** (<https://alsa.com/>)
- **DAMAS** (<https://damas-sa.es/>)

See

- **Moorish architecture** in Granada, including the Alhambra.
- **Lake Negratin** is situated at the foothills of Mount Jabalcón. As one of Europe's largest lakes, it really is worth seeing not least for the most magnificent lunar-landscape that surrounds it. The rock formations and the colours it produces during different times of the day can be likened to those of the Grand Canyon. There is a manmade beach where you can laze the day away, a number of restaurants dotted round the lake and on a nice day you can swim or take out a pedalo boat, which might lead you to pink flamingos and various other wildlife.
- **Seron** is nestled on the lower slopes of the Sierra de los Filabres and is a picturesque town that cascades down the hillside. Dominated by its Castle, which sits at the very top, Seron is famous for its ham and provides a more traditional experience of Andalusian life. It is a beautiful location to start your exploration of the Filabres, or visit at the right time of year and you might find yourself submerged in a vibrant fiesta.
- **Las Menas**, an old mining village abandoned thirty years ago, makes an interesting stop in the Sierra de los Filabres. You can investigate old ruins crumbling amidst the most breathtaking countryside, stop for coffee and cake at the hotel and even camp for the night.
- Visit the UNESCO World Network of Biosphere Reserves in andalusia:
 - Grazalema
 - Doñana
 - Las Sierras de Cazorla y Segura
 - Marismas del Odiel
 - Sierra Nevada
 - Sierra de las Nieves y su Entorno
 - Cabo de Gata-Níjar
 - Las Dehesas de Sierra Morena
 - Intercontinental Biosphere Reserve of the Mediterranean

Do

- **Andaventur Granada Adventure Company** (<http://www.andaventur.com/>). Outdoor sports in the Sierra Nevada National park and Granada province, Tandem paraglider flights, Canyoning, Hiking, Ski, Rock Climbing, Horse riding.



- Long clean **beaches** on the Costa del Sol and the Costa de la Luz.
- **Walking** and **hiking** in the Sierra Nevada
- **Rock Climbing Company** (<http://www.rockclimbingcompany.co.uk/>), ☎ +34 952 742 962, +44 1492 641430. High quality rock climbing and scrambling courses in Andalusia. Courses based in Malaga province both on the coast and also inland near to the El Chorro gorge.
- **Windsurfing and kiting** in Tarifa, Spain's southern tip
- **Horse riding and Spain** go hand-in-hand and with such spectacular mountain ranges at your disposal as the Sierra Nevada and Alpujarra Hills; you have a feast of beautiful Andalusian trekking land to indulge in astride your faithful friend. There are several stables situated in these areas, and all offer the option to ride for an hour, a day, or even as long as 7 nights. Accommodation and food are included in prices and the whole experience offers a unique way to see this amazing part of Spain. Prices vary from €25 to €1200 and there are so many options to choose from that you will undoubtedly find something to suit your level and requirements.
- **Flamenco** is the all-Andalusian art with a history stretching back over 3,000 years. The Museo del Baile Flamenco (<http://www.museoflamenco.com>) (Flamenco Dance Museum) is the ideal place to learn more about this phenomenon. Shows are offered on Friday and Saturday nights at 19:30, too.

Events

- **Andalusia day** (*Día de Andalucía*): 28 February annually. Commemorates the February 28, 1980 referendum on the Statute of Autonomy of Andalusia, in which Andalusians achieved recognition for an autonomous region within the state of Spain.

Eat

Drink

Sleep

Stay safe

Andalusia is a very safe region; cities and villages alike are safe if you are smart and don't do anything stupid. However, places like Malaga, Marbella, Fuengirola, and Seville attract millions of tourists yearly, and as with most heavily touristy places, some foreigners will end up partying like animals, despite the police's efforts to keep the peace.

In Granada and Cordoba, it is advisable to avoid women offering plants (usually heather). They will offer you a plant for free, and then when you accept it, they will read your palm and demand money. If you refuse to give it to them, they may start screaming at you, and you will generally want to avoid this situation. Aside from this, the area is usually very safe, but one should still take the usual precautions, especially in Malaga, Seville, etc.

Despite the strong agricultural and tourism sectors, Andalusia has some of the poorest towns in Spain; cities like Jerez, Cadiz, Huelva, and Almeria all have unemployment rates well above 20%. As such, opportunistic crimes like pickpockets do occur.

While parts of the Andalusian coast have made headlines for scenes of migrant boats landing on beaches, they are not as frequent as the media might suggest, and most of the time, migrants tend to stick to themselves if left alone.

Go next

- **Alentejo** — sparsely populated region in Portugal's southern plains
 - **Algarve** — popular beach and resort region in southern Portugal
 - **Gibraltar**
 - **Morocco**
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